Beijing."[255] Bowles, his successor, believed that even if US messages via India were not passed on to—or heeded by—China, using the India channel would help convince Delhi that, unlike Beijing, Washington was doing its part to seek peace.[256] Dean Rusk, assistant secretary of state for Far East Asian affairs, found Indian contacts with Chinese officials useful for conveying warnings of potential US retaliation if China escalated.[257] For Acheson, as long as the US had multiple channels, India's good relations with China and its standing with other Asian countries made the continued use of this channel worthwhile.[258]

However, there were also serious doubts about India as a conduit.[259] There were questions about India's reliability and its officials' judgment as to China's intentions. The US Army chief believed Beijing was manipulating India.[260] In addition, there was unease that Panikkar was proposing ideas or interpretations to Chinese officials that the US had not approved, while suggesting to Beijing that the proposals had resulted from close contact with Washington.[261] There were also doubts about whether roving Indian envoys like Krishna Menon were even keeping Delhi in the loop on US views. Furthermore, there was concern that US officials did not know what Delhi was actually saying to Panikkar and what he was conveying to Chinese officials.[262]

Other officials worried that India would compromise principles and ignore US red lines in order to achieve any settlement.[263] In Congress, Senator H. Alexander Smith (R-NJ)—usually a moderate on India—worried that Delhi would try to force the US to make concessions to China in order to enhance Nehru's image and influence in Asia.[264] In discussions with Panikkar and Krishna Menon, American officials felt there was a lack of clarity about whether they were hearing those officials' personal views or Chinese ones, or Indian preferences rather than Chinese ones.[265] There were only more doubts when Chinese actions did not reflect Beijing's apparent attitudes as assessed by Panikkar.[266]

These doubts about India as an intermediary led Washington to try to limit its role at times, which Indian officials resented. While Zhou indicated that China wanted India to be included in some negotiations, the US showed little desire to include India in groups like the Good Offices Committee (India, on its part, showed little desire to serve on the latter).[267] And despite British urging, the US resisted consulting India on a sixteen-